CE 392

Prerequisite:
CE29202

Instructor

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Office Location

Hampton 4111

Office Hours

1-2p, TR

Class Times and Locations

Lecture 001 3:30-4:20pm T, ME G061

Recitation 003 2:30-3:20pm R, HAMP 2123

Recitation 004 3:30-4:20pm R, HAMP 2123

Recitation 005 9:30-10:20am T, FRNY 1043

Technical Communication in Civil Engineering

Course Overview

CE39201 builds upon the technical communication components of CE29202, adding rhetorical theory and practice, large projects, and oral presentation. This course challenges students to develop arguments based on sound rhetorical principles and then adapt those arguments into different media. This course is intended to be taken near the end of a student's degree program, ideally just before enrolling in Senior Design. Skills acquired in this class will be used throughout the professional civil engineer's career as he or she interacts with other engineers and the general public. Assignments and activities in this class may be coordinated with other CE courses being taken by students in CE39201.

Course Goals

This class gives students a chance to practice public speaking to audiences large and small. It asks students to learn the physical tools of speech by practicing control of pitch, pace, and volume. It teaches the foundations of classical rhetoric in the discovery of and proper arrangement of arguments, and it focuses on the particular communication needs of engineering students by discussing best practices for explaining complex systems. Students should leave the class with the necessary skills to communicate effectively with a range of audiences. By the end of the semester students should be able to do the following:

1. Apply standards of effective professional communication for a range of audiences to the common speaking tasks required by the profession of civil engineering
2. Recognize and apply the standards of classical rhetoric to common persuasive tasks.

3. Develop habits to improve speaking ability throughout the career.

Assignments

There are three major assignments: instruction, performance, and argument. Points are awarded for practice and for the quality of the presentation according to the rubrics found on Brightspace. Assignments are not accepted past the due dates posted online and may not be revised once submitted.

Quizzes are also assigned for every lecture and are due before the next lecture begins.

Grading Scale

All points gained throughout the semester add to a sum which determines your final letter grade. Each assignment is worth approximately 20 points, with some possibility for bonus points on the third assignment. Point totals receive final letter grades according to the following scale: 90+=A, 80-89=B, 70-79=C, 60-69=D, below 60=F.

Note that CE 39201 is a core class for the school of civil engineering. Students must pass with a C or better to continue in the major.

Attendance and Academic Guidance

Because this class involves public speaking, attendance is important, as it provides an audience for practice. Two unexcused absences are permitted, with further unexcused absences penalized at -5 points per absence. This penalty will be assessed at the end of the semester. Absences will be excused if notice is provided before class.

If you are ill or exhibit symptoms of illness, stay home and contact me to secure an excused absence. If you must quarantine or are otherwise unable to attend, notify your academic advisor and myself as soon as possible. Arrangements will be made on a case-by-case basis.

All relevant Purdue University classroom policies apply to this course.

Course Schedule

The course is divided into three units of approximately 5 weeks each.

Unit 1: Instruction (Weeks 1-6)

Our goal in these first weeks is to come to grips with the nature of language and its uses in creation, construction, and consensus. The assignment for this unit is an instruction for a small group. The focus for the assignment is clarity in terms and building consensus through understanding.

Unit 2: Performance (Week 7-11)

Our goal for the second third of the semester is practice with the rhetorical arts of Memory, Delivery, and Style. The assignment for this unit is a memorized speech. The focus for the assignment is development of memory, vocal control and body language.

Unit 3: Argument (Week 12-16)

Our goal for the the final third of the semester is practice with the rhetorical arts of Discovery and Arrangement. The assignment for this unit is an annotated slide deck. The focus for the assignment is applying rhetorical tools and choosing persuasive topics.